

A Guide to Reaching a Checkout

It's an undeniable fact that you can't hit a checkout until you reach a Posted by [Greg](#) January 26, 2021
checkout. How you get from 501 down to a number that can be taken out is not just a matter of scoring as many points as possible until you reach a score of 170 or less. There are pitfalls along the way that must be avoided. Land on the wrong number and you will be forced to waste darts to reestablish a clear path to a double.

The highest score you can take out in three darts is 170, which makes 350 the highest score you can take out in six darts (180-170). So that's your first goal in 501 – leave a score below 351 that can be taken out in six darts.

You'll see many mentions below to bogey numbers. What I mean by this is that there are scores that require more darts to finish than would be required by a slightly higher score. Here's an example:

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
439	100 leaves a bogey	99: T20-S20-S19	340

Starting with 439 and scoring 100 leaves 339. How is this a bogey? I addressed this in detail in a previous post ([The Bogey Numbers](#)), but to make a long story short, 339 can not be taken out in six darts whereas 340 can. So you're better off throwing 99 to leave 340 than 100 to leave 339. Makes sense, right?

Just to be clear, if you start with a score of 439 I'm not suggesting you should throw a 99. By all means, throw a 180 or 140. But if you throw a treble 20 with your first dart and hit the single 20 with your second dart, do not throw the third dart at the treble 20 – throw at the treble 19 and if it lands in the single 19 the resulting 99 leaves you on 340.

The suggested throws are provided to give you an idea of what you'll need to throw to reach your goal, and to help you avoid the bogeys that will force you to throw more darts. If you can score more points than the suggested throw, and avoid a bogey, by all means do so.

Tip: All bogey numbers (above 50) end in the digits 2, 3, 5, 6, 8, 9 – so, when in doubt, leave a score that ends in 0, 1, 4, or 7.

Let's look at some starting score ranges to see what you'll need to throw, and what you'll need to avoid, to reach a checkout.

501-451

At the start of a leg of 501, you'll need to hit three big trebles (or two and the bull) to get below 351 and keep your hopes for a 9-darter alive. If you stumble out of the gate with a poor first round, two big trebles are enough to get you back in the race for a 12 dart leg. Unfortunately, there are many minefields for starting scores in this range. Two treble 20's and a stray outside the 20 – (think: 121, 123, 125, 135) can result in a bogey for many of these starting scores, as can a poorly considered cover shot.

In summary, do your math here and avoid ending the round with a score of 349, 348, 346, 345, 343, 342, or 339, as these scores make it impossible to leave a checkout after the next round.

With most of this range, a score of 140 will get you to your goal, with the exception of a just a few of the scores listed below which will require a bit more finesse to reach a safe number below 351.

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
501	Need 3 big trebles (but not three T18's)	180, 177, 174, 171	321-330
500-491	Need 3 big trebles	180, 177, 174, 171, 170, 168, 165, 162	
490	140 will get you to 350	140: 7 20's	350
489	140 leaves a bogey S20 1st dart leaves a bogey	142: T19-T20-25 139: S19-T20-T20	347 350
488	140 & 139 leave a bogey S20 or S19 with 1st dart leaves a bogey	138: S18-T20-T20	350
487	140 is good Avoid: 139, 138	140: 7 20's	347
486	Good: 142, 139, 136 Avoid: 140, 138, 137 S20 1st dart leaves a bogey	142: T19-T20-25 139: S19-T20-T20 136: S19-T19-T20	344 347 350
485	Good: 138, 135 Avoid: 140, 139, 137, 136 S20 or S19 with 1st dart leaves a bogey	138: S18-T20-T20	347
484	Good: 140, 137, 134 Avoid: 139, 138, 136, 135	140: 7 20's 137: T20-S20-T19 134: S20-T19-T19	344 347 350
483	Good: 142, 139, 136, 133 Avoid: 140 Avoid: 138, 137, 135, 134 S20 1st dart leaves a bogey	142: T19-T20-25 139: S19-T20-T20 136: S19-T19-T20 133: 7 19's	341 344 347 350
482	Good: 138, 135, 132 Avoid: 140, 139, 137 Avoid: 136, 134, 133 S20 or S19 with 1st dart leaves a bogey	138: S18-T20-T20	344
481	Good: 140, 137, 134, 131 Avoid: 139, 138, 136 Avoid: 135, 133, 132	140: 7 20's 137: T20-S20-T19 134: S20-T19-T19 131: T20-S20-T17	341 344 347 350
480	Good: 140, 139, 136, 133, 130 Avoid: 138, 137, 135 Avoid: 134, 132, 131	140: 7 20's 139: T20-T20-S19 136: T20-T19-S19 133: 7 19's	340 341 344 347
479	Good: 142, 139, 138 Good: 135, 132, 129 Avoid: 140, 137, 136 Avoid: 134, 133, 131, 130 S20 1st dart leaves a bogey	142: T19-T20-25 139: S19-T20-T20	337 340
478-451	140 is good here, but for each of these there are several scores	140: 7 20's	338-311

	in the 102-139 range that will leave a bogey. Be careful.		
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Notice for 489, 488, 486, 485, 483, 482, and 479, we're not throwing the first dart at treble 20. This is because a single 20 will put you on a bogey. For instance, if you score 20 from 489 you'll be left with 469 from which you can not reach a score with your two remaining darts that can be taken out in the next two rounds. Start on 19's and if you hit the single, two treble 20's will take you to 350 for the next round. For 488, 485, and 482, single 19 also puts you on a bogey, so start with 18.

Here are two opportunities to make use of the bull with your third dart:

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
455	105 leaves a 6 dart checkout	105: T20-S20-25	350
452	105 leaves a 6 dart checkout	105: T20-S20-25	347

450-351

Generally speaking, you don't need to score more than 100 from here to have a chance to leave a checkout after the next round. However, the danger zone mentioned above (349, 348, 346, 345, 343, 342, 339) still must be avoided, as noted in the chart below:

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
450	Good: 100 Avoid: 101, 102, 104, 105 Avoid: 107, 108, 111	100: 5 20's	350
449	100 leaves a bogey	99: T20-S20-S19 99: S20-S19-T20 102: S20-T19-25	350 350 347
448	100 leaves a bogey	98: T20-S20-S18 98: S20-S18-T20	350
447	Good: 100, 97	100: 5 20's 97: S20-S20-T19	347 350
446	100 leaves a bogey	99: T20-S20-S19 99: S20-S19-T20 102: S20-T19-25	347 347 344
445	100 leaves a bogey	98: T20-S20-S18 98: S20-S18-T20	347
444	Good: 100, 97, 94	100: 5 20's 97: S20-S20-T19 94: S20-S20-T18	344 347 350
443	100 leaves a bogey	99: T20-S20-S19 99: S20-S19-T20 102: S20-T19-25	344 344 341
442	100 leaves a bogey	98: T20-S20-S18 98: S20-S18-T20	344

441	Good: 100, 97, 94, 91	100: 5 20's 97: S20-S20-T19 94: S20-S20-T18 91: S20-S20-T17	341 344 347 350
440	Good: 100, 99, 96	100: 5 20's 99: T20-S20-S19 96: S20-T19-S19	340 341 344
439	100 leaves a bogey	99: T20-S20-S19 99: S20-S19-T20 102: S20-T19-25	340 340 337
438- 416, 414, 413, 411	100 leaves a 6 dart checkout. Beware of scores just below 100 that may leave a bogey	100: 5 20's	338- 316, 314, 313, 311
415	65 leaves a 6 dart checkout	65: S20-S20-25	350
412	65 leaves a 6 dart checkout	65: S20-S20-25	347
410	60 leaves a 6 dart checkout.	60: 3 20's	350
409	60 leaves a bogey	59: S20-S20-S19	350
408	60 leaves a bogey	58: S20-S20-S18	350
407	60 leaves a 6 dart checkout.	60: 3 20's	347
406	60 leaves a bogey	59: S20-S20-S19	347
405	60 leaves a bogey	58: S20-S20-S18	347
404	60 leaves a 6 dart checkout.	60: 3 20's	344
403	60 leaves a bogey	59: S20-S20-S19	344
402	60 leaves a bogey	58: S20-S20-S18	344
401	60 leaves a 6 dart checkout.	60: 3 20's	341
400	60 or more will leave you on a 6 dart checkout. (Other than 61. Don't throw 61.)	60: 3 20's 100: 5 20's 140: 7 20's 180: 9 20's	340 300 260 220
399	60 leaves a bogey	59: S20-S20-S19	340
398- 351	60 or more will leave you on a 6 dart checkout.	60: 3 20's 100: 5 20's 140: 7 20's 180: 9 20's	338-291 298-251 258-211 218-171

As mentioned previously, the advice here isn't to throw a 58 from 408. The suggestion is that if your first two attempts at treble 20 land in the single 20, throw the third dart at the 18's.

If you look the last row above, you will see that scores of 60-180 will all leave you on a 6 dart checkout. There are no bogeys in this range, so score as much as you can. The more you can score from here the easier it will be to

leave a good checkout after the next round.

350-291

At the top of this range you'll need three big trebles to reach a score of 170 or less (avoiding the bogey numbers 169, 168, 166, 165, 163, 162, 159). A score of 140 is sufficient at the bottom of the range.

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
350, 347, 344, 341	180 leaves a checkout	180: T20-T20-T20	170-161
349, 348, 346, 345, 343, 342, 339	Bogey numbers. Can't reach a checkout with three darts.	Don't ask me. I told you not to land on these numbers.	
340	Only 180 or 170 will do	180: T20-T20-T20 170: T20-T20-Bull	160 170
338 337 336, 333 335, 332 334 331 330	Need 3 big trebles 180, 177, 174, 171 180, 177, 170 180 180, 177, 174, 171 180, 177, 174, 170 180, 177, 174, 171 180, 177, 174, 170	180: T20-T20-T20 177: T20-T20-T19 174: T20-T20-T18 171: T19-T19-T19 171: T20-T19-T18 170: T20-T20-Bull	
329-316	140 is not enough – need 3 big trebles	180, 177, 174, 171	
315	140 is not enough 145 leaves a checkout	145: T20-T20-25	170
314, 313	140 is not enough – need 3 big trebles	180, 177, 174, 171	
312	140 is not enough 145 leaves a checkout	145: T20-T20-25	167
311	140 is not enough – need 3 big trebles	180, 177, 174, 171	
310	140 leaves a checkout	140: 7 20's	170
309	139 or 142 leaves a checkout Throw 1st dart at 19's	142: T19-T20-25 139: S19-T20-T20	167 170
308	138 leaves a checkout Throw 1st dart at 18	138: S18-T20-T20	170
307	140 leaves a checkout	140: 7 20's	167
306	140 is no good Throw first dart at 19's 136, 139, 142 leave a checkout	142: T19-T19-25 136: T19-S19-T20 139: S19-T20-T20	164 170 167
305	140 is no good S20 or S19 1st dart is no good 135, 138, 145 leave a checkout	145: 25-T20-T20 138: 18-T20-T20 135: 15-T20-T20	170 167 160

304	140 leaves 164 Avoid: 135, 136, 138, 139	140: 7 20's	164
303	140 is no good Throw first dart at 19's 133, 136, 139 leave a checkout	133: 7 19's 136: T19-S19-T20 139: S19-T20-T20	170 167 164
302	140 is no good Throw first dart at 18's 132, 135, 138 leave a checkout	132: T18-S18-T20 135: S18-T19-T20 138: S18-T20-T20	170 167 164
301	140 leaves a checkout	140: 7 20's	161
300	140 leaves a checkout	140: 7 20's	160
299	140 is no good Throw first dart at 19's 129, 135, 139 leave a checkout	129: T19-T18-S18 135: T19-S18-T20 139: S19-T20-T20	170 164 160
298	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 139, 136, 135 Avoid: 133, 132, 130, 129	140: 7 20's	158
297	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 138, 135, 134 Avoid: 132, 131, 129, 128	140: 7 20's	157
296	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 137, 134, 133 Avoid: 131, 130, 128, 127	140: 7 20's	156
295	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 136, 133, 132 Avoid: 130, 129, 127, 126	140: 7 20's	155
294	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 135, 132, 131 Avoid: 129, 128, 126, 125	140: 7 20's	154
293	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 134, 131, 130 Avoid: 128, 127, 125, 124	140: 7 20's	153
292	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 133, 130, 129 Avoid: 127, 126, 124, 123	140: 7 20's	152
291	140 leaves a checkout Avoid: 132, 129, 128, Avoid: 126, 125, 123, 122	140: 7 20's	151

Notice for 309, 308, 306, 305, 303, 302, and 299, we're not throwing the first dart at treble 20. This is because a single 20 will put you on a bogey. For instance, if you score 20 from 309 you'll be left with 289 from which you can not reach a checkout with your two remaining darts. Start on 19's and if you hit the single, two treble 20's will take you to 170 for the next round. For 308, 305, 302 a single 19 is also a bogey, so start with 18.

290-231

A score of 140 is good at the top of this range, scores around 100 will work in the middle and 60 is not quite enough at the bottom of the range. A big score could leave you with a two dart checkout.

Bogey numbers to avoid: 169, 168, 166, 165, 163, 162, 159

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
290-276	Need two big trebles. 140 is good. Beware of bogeys for scores of 107-131	140: 7 20's	150-136
275	100 is not enough 105 leaves a checkout	105: 4 20's + 25	170
274	100 is not enough 104 leaves a checkout	104: T20-S19-25	170
273	100 is not enough 103 leaves a checkout	103: T20-S18-25	170
272	100 is not enough 105 leaves a checkout	105: 4 20's + 25	167
271	100 is not enough 101 or 104 leaves a checkout	101: T19-S19-25 104: S19-T20-25	170 167
270	100 leaves a checkout	100: 5 20's	170
269	100 is no good 99 or 102 leaves a checkout	102: T19-S20-25 99: S19-T20-20	167 170
268	100 is no good 98 leaves a checkout	98: T18-S19-25 98: S18-T20-S20	170
267	100 leaves a checkout	100: 5 20's	167
266	100 is no good 96 or 99 leaves a checkout	96: T19-S19-S20 99: S19-T20-S20	170 167
265	100 is no good 95 or 98 leaves a checkout	95: 5 19's 98: S19-S19-T20	170 167
264	100 leaves a checkout	100: 5 20's	164
263	100 is no good 96 or 99 leaves a checkout	99: T20-S20-S19 96: S20-T19-S19	164 167
262	100 is no good 95 or 98 leaves a checkout	95: 5 19's 98: S19-S19-T20	167 164
261	100 leaves a checkout	100: 5 20's	161
260	100 leaves a checkout	100: 5 20's	160
259	100 is no good 95 or 99 leaves a checkout	95: 5 19's 99: S19-T20-S20	164 160
258-236	100 leaves a checkout Beware of scores below 100 that may leave a bogey	100: 5 20's	158-136
235	60 is not enough 65 will leave a checkout	65: S20-S20-25	170

234	60 is not enough 64 will leave a checkout	64: S20-S19-25	170
233	60 is not enough 63 will leave a checkout	63: S19-S19-25	170
232	60 is not enough 65 will leave a checkout	65: S20-S20-25	167
231	60 is not enough 61 will leave a checkout	61: S18-S18-25	170

230-171

At this point you don't need more than three big singles to leave you on a checkout for the next round, but one and two dart checkouts can be reached with a big score.

Bogey numbers to avoid: 169, 168, 166, 165, 163, 162, 159

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
230	60 leaves a checkout. Don't throw a cover shot after two 20's	60: 3 20's	170
229	60 leaves a bogey so move to 19's after two single 20's	59: S20-S20-S19	170
228	60 leaves a bogey so move to 18's after two single 20's	58: S20-S20-S18	170
227	60 leaves a checkout	60: 3 20's 57: S20-S20-S17 57: 3 19's	167 170 170
226	60 leaves a bogey so move to 19's after two single 20's	59: S20-S20-S19	167
225	60 leaves a bogey so move to 15, 18 or bull after two 20's	65: S20-S20-25 58: S20-S20-S18 55: S20-S20-S15	160 167 170
224	60 leaves a checkout	60: 3 20's 57: S20-S20-S17 57: 3 19's	164 167 167
223	60 leaves a bogey so move to 19's after two single 20's	59: S20-S20-S19	164
222	60 leaves a bogey so move to 15, 18 or bull after two 20's	65: S20-S20-25 58: S20-S20-S18 55: S20-S20-S15	157 164 167
221	60 leaves a checkout	60: 3 20's 57: S20-S20-S17 57: 3 19's	161 164 164
220	60 leaves a checkout	60: 3 20's 59: S20-S20-S19	160 161

219	60 leaves a bogey so move to 19's after two single 20's	59: S20-S20-S19	160
218-171	60 leaves a checkout	60: 3 20's	158-111

170-159

If you've been paying attention, you're on a checkout – so take it out!

If not, you're not. Do your best to clean up the mess and take it out next round. If you get a next round.

Score	Comment	Throw	Leave
170 167 164 161	Take it out! (With 161, S20-S20-25 gets you below 100)	T20-T20-Bull T20-T19-Bull T19-T19-Bull T20-T17-Bull	
169	If you'd thrown one less point somewhere along the way, you'd be on a checkout now.	137: T20-T20-S17	32
168	If you'd thrown one more point somewhere along the way, you'd be on a checkout now.	136: T20-T20-S16	32
166	This is an awful number to leave. You can't even do something cute with the bull to fix it. What were you thinking?	134: T20-T20-S14	32
165	Hello? This isn't a checkout. 2 20's and a single bull leaves 100	133: 7 19's 65: S20-S20-25	32 100
163	2 20's and a single bull leaves 98	131: T20-T19-S14 65: S20-S20-25	32 98
162	2 20's and a single bull leaves 97	130: T20-T20-S10 65: S20-S20-25	32 97
160	Take it out if you can, but don't throw a cover shot after two single 20's – 60 leaves a 2 dart checkout.	T20-T20-D20	
159	A) You shouldn't be here B) Don't leave 99	127: T20-T19-S10 59: S20-S20-S19	32 100

Tip: Calculate your score remaining after every dart thrown. You'll make fewer mistakes if you know your exact score before you throw your next dart.